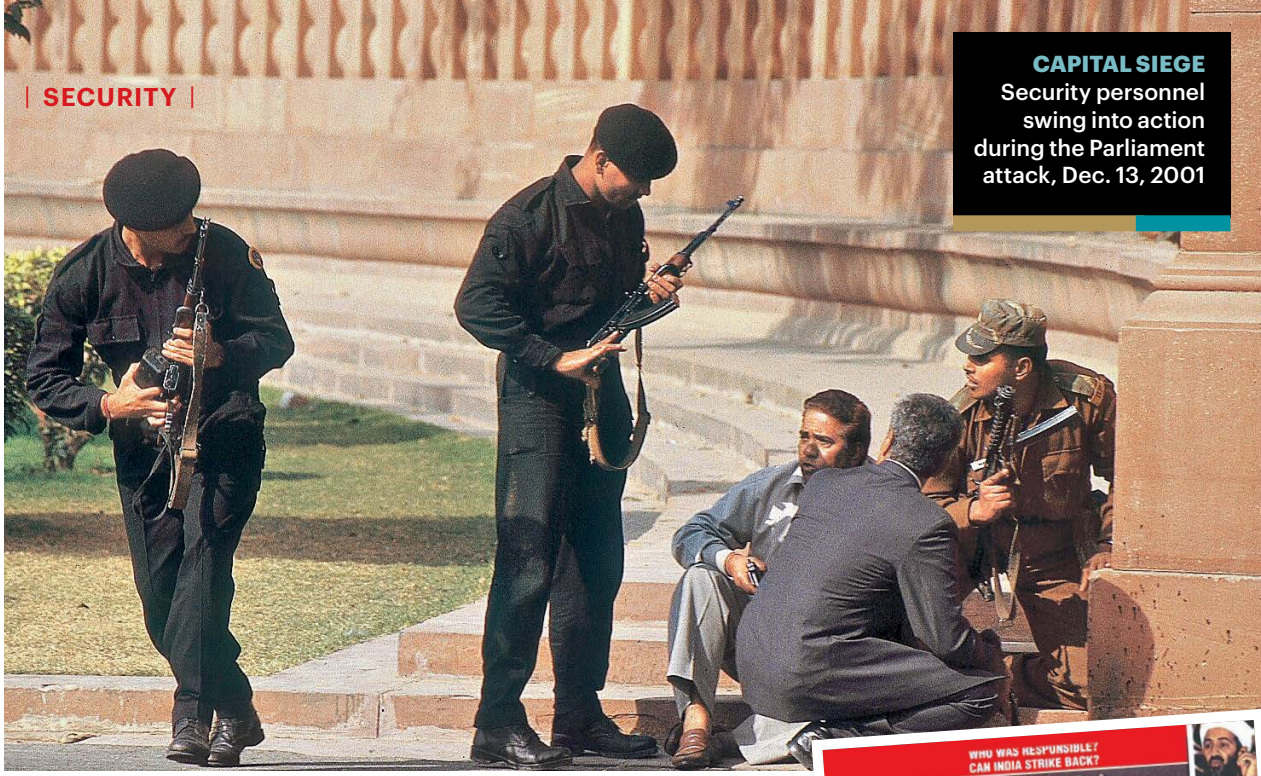


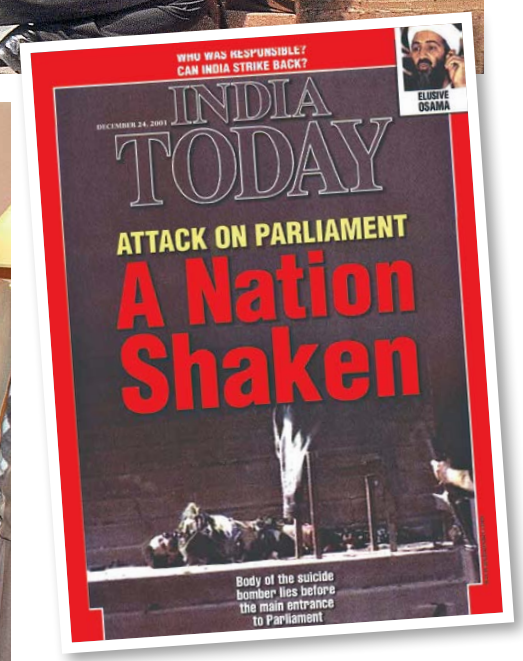
BANDEEP SINGH

CAPITAL SIEGE
Security personnel swing into action during the Parliament attack, Dec. 13, 2001



AP

BROKERING PEACE
Vajpayee meets Hurriyat leaders in New Delhi, Jan. 23, 2004



▲ *Dec. 24, 2001*

and a yen for rewriting history in bold typeface and charmingly cursive words. He once floored the Hurriyat by abandoning the stiffly officious line New Delhi had clung to: that the Kashmir problem would be solved "within the ambit of the Constitution". Instead, he said, "*insaaniyat ke daayre mein*"—within the ambit of humanism! Politically, too, everyone felt if peace with Pakistan was to be signed and delivered, only a BJP government could do it without fear.

Spoken too soon, alas. The forbidding hardliner was not outside, but within. L.K. Advani, Vajpayee's home minister, was never quite convinced. At the summit meet in Agra in July 2001, Musharraf emerged from the state limo, strode onto the red carpet, dispensed his salutes to the cameras, and walked in to a hall where history was waiting to be made with a flourish of the pen. A subcontinent, too, waited with bated breath. But after nine hours of haggling over two days, only bitterness was reaped. Almost as if to seal any chance of peace erupting accidentally, the December 2001 attack on Parliament congealed sentiments on all sides.

Kashmir made a valiant attempt on its own too. Even Hizbul supremo Syed Salahuddin sent out a peace emissary in Abdul Majid Dar, but he was slain in 2003, like Abdul Gani Lone was a year before him—that too at a commemoration for Mirwaiz Moulvi Farooq, who was assassinated in 1990. There were obstacles to peace on both sides. ■